Ahmedabad Collectorate to file his nomination papers for the Maninagar constituency. It remained a constant refrain at Modi rallies thereafter.

Back then, Modi also seemed to attract more women attendees than men in rally after rally. Many of us reporting on him noticed that they seemed to react more visibly to his speeches than the men did, especially when he used his catchphrases like 'chhappanee chhatee'. In my memory, the many Gaurav Yatra rallies I attended were less like political roadshows and more like an Indian version of what a Beatles rock concert might be like, where people came for darshan. At one particular rally in a village in Mehsana district, as Modi was speaking, the village temple's bells began to ring to signify the evening aarti, or prayer. Mid-speech, he stopped and said, '*Meri mataon aur behenon, mandir mein aartee shuru ho gayee hai, iska intezaar karte hain* [My mothers and sisters, the temple prayer has begun, let's wait for it].' There was pin-drop silence in the crowd, as he waited for the aarti to finish before resuming his speech. We did not realise it then, but Modi seemed to have become a Gujarati sanskari sex symbol. This phenomenon was noted by several commentators, including the Gujarati newspaper editor Aakar Patel, who later headed Amnesty International in India. 'Gujarati women absolutely adore him,' Patel wrote. 'Modi, though he may not acknowledge this, is a sex symbol in his home state. The ratio of women to men for his meetings and gatherings is higher than it is for other politicians in the state. He has the aura of a king or emperor, someone who exudes absolute power and authority, and therefore someone irresistible to women.'[11]

By 2007, this tactic had been turned into women-focused outreach and development strategies. When Modi addressed election rallies that year, they all featured special messages for the attending women. Often, he exhorted women to remember him before they cooked food in their homes on voting day. He would turn to the women and say in Gujarati, '*Behenon, pehle NaMo, fir jamo* [Sisters, first NaMo, then cooking].' This one-liner on voting and cooking 'always won laughs from the women in the audience and applause', remembers the journalist Sanjeev Singh, who covered